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The Relational Becoming of a Participatory Design Commoner

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NORDES 2025

THE RELATIONAL BECOMING OF A PARTICIPATORY DESIGN COMMONER

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ABSTRACT

This research expands the understanding of the collective designer behind Scandinavian Participatory Design with the Latin American notion of relational ontology, which posits a worldview where everything and everyone are mutually constituted through evolving relationships. Drawing from three thematic workshops with design practitioners and scholars that explored intersections between commoning and designing, this research unveils the relational becoming of a participatory design commoner. This includes the production of a shared subjectivity—the collective designer—as integral to commoning design and designing commons. Specifically, we explore the role of participatory designers in commoning through their subjectivity in their infrastructuring actions and affective engagements with objective commons.

INTRODUCTION

In broad terms, commons can be thought of as entanglements of shared resources, people, institutions, rules, and principles, which a human collective cares to maintain, sustain, and preserve. In this paper, our understanding of commons goes beyond the conventional focus on managing shared resources, acknowledging the politics of producing something in common, and organizing the typical messiness that entangled affective relations bring along. Rather, we align with emergent positions that consider commoning as primarily being about taking care of relationships between and in-between human and other-than-human actors (Bollier, 2014; Poderi, 2019).

In this line of thinking, commons do not exist before the process of sharing resources. Some authors go as far as to use the verb “commoning” in addition to commons as a noun to emphasize the longitudinal aspect of taking care of what is shared (cf. Linebaugh, 2009; Bollier & Helfrich, 2019). By commoning resources over time, commoners produce both a shared objectivity—the

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resources pool—and a shared subjectivity—the sense of being a collective self (Poderi, 2021; Cibin et al., 2020) who cares or belongs to a common (Dardot et al., 2019). This shared subjectivity shapes how commoners think, feel, and act in the world (Singh, 2017).

Design research has made significant contributions to the commoning literature by foregrounding the design aspect of commoning activities. As insightful as these were to pose a dialectics between commoning and designing (e.g. Botero et al., 2020), design research has not yet touched upon the challenge of designing shared subjectivity as part of commoning, i.e. becoming a collective designer (Ehn & Badham, 2002). Aiming to fill this gap, this research asks: What are subjective aspects of commoning and designing that contemporary designers recognize and produce in their practice? Furthermore, how does shared subjectivity emerge from a designed (and self-designing) entanglement of humans and other-than-humans that care for the commons?

To answer these questions, we rely on the notion of relational ontology (Escobar, 2018; Escobar et al., 2024). In this, the relations between beings are ontologically more fundamental to reality than the beings themselves. When assembling what is real, a relational ontology usually displaces the individualized human subject, its rationality, and its agency over the world from the center of discourse, letting the otherwise neglected affective entanglements emerge (Kothari et al., 2019; Eleutério & Van Amstel, 2020). The traditional dichotomic separations such as human-nature, structure-agency, or body-mind, are questioned and the focus is turned towards totalities, emergences, entanglements and co-becomings (Singh, 2017; Velicu & García-López, 2018; Light et al., 2024).

While being aware of the existing, and growing, sensibility towards relationality in design (Escobar et al., 2024; Agid & Akama, 2018; Fry, 2020; Arturo Ortega Alvarado, 2024) and especially in Participatory Design (PD) (Akama et al., 2019; Akama & Light, 2018; Light & Akama, 2014, Light et al., 2024; Lindström & Ståhl, 2014; 2019), we explore, in this paper, whether and how the perspective of relational ontology can shed new light onto the process of becoming a participatory design commoner. Specifically, we describe and discuss empirical instances drawing from three thematic workshops, where we explored the intersections between designing and commoning practices. Two aspects related to designing and commoning were explored. First, the role and position of a designer engaging with commons, thus becoming part of a collective designer that designs as a single yet multifarious entity: the participatory collective designer. Second, the relational ways of being in common to take care of the commons: being a commoner. When converging these two becomings (Singh, 2017, see also Federici, 2018; Light & Akama, 2014; Akama & Light, 2018, Light et al., 2024), we seek inspiration from care ethics and commitment to nurture and sustain relationships (Lindström & Ståhl, 2019, Light et al., 2024; Heitlinger et al., 2025) and Singh's (2017) understanding of affect as "the power to affect and being affected, and the relationship between these two" (p. 758). Singh draws our attention to situated social practices that care for these relations, arguing that "commons can be conceptualized as a site of affective socio-nature encounters or as affective socio-nature relations that can foster subjectivities of 'being in common' with others" (p. 754).

We start our paper by framing our collective design research approach, positioning commons and commoning, and discussing the relational dimensions in contemporary design research and practice. Thereafter, we present our three empirical instances —the experimental workshops — and reflect upon converging insights from our experiments and the available literature. We conclude the paper with a discussion on the relational becoming of a participatory design commoner and its implications for design research.

A COLLECTIVE DESIGN RESEARCH APPROACH

Our research approach is inspired by the tradition of "democratic design experiments" (Binder et al., 2015; Lindström & Ståhl, 2019; DiSalvo, 2022) that foregrounds the collective over individuals, and builds upon collaborative and caring practices in design participation. As part of our long-term commitment to explore the dialectics between commoning and designing (Marttila et al., 2014; Botero et al., 2020) we have run thematic workshops as democratic design experiments, in the spirit of inventive methods (Lury & Wakeford, 2012) looking for clues on the associated production of shared objectivity and subjectivity. As individual research subjects, we positioned ourselves as workshop hosts, facilitators, and complicators—the ones who complicate dialogue through insurgence and reality problematization (Van Amstel et al., 2021). As a collective subject formed by those individuals, we also positioned ourselves as research objects, thus challenging the Modern scientific reliance on subject-object split, discursive neutrality, and alienated impartiality. To construct ourselves as a research subject, we build on the notions of collective designer (Ehn & Badham, 2002), Things (Ehn, 2008), collective design body (Angelon & Van Amstel, 2021) and pluriversal designers (Escobar, 2024), which frame design participants, be they experts in design or in other topics, humans or other-than-humans, as becoming a single entity with a design agency.

To gather up this shared subjectivity, we relied upon shared objective data such as voice and screen recordings, field notes, preparatory documents, such as

collective meeting notes from the planning meetings as well as position papers submitted by the participants prior to the workshop, and workshop outcomes in the form of maps, diagrams, and cards. To reassemble the social (Latour, 2005) in this research project, we developed a ”relational sensitivity” (Akama & Light, 2018; Akama, 2015) for researcher-to-researcher affective exchanges. That sensibility entailed recognizing the invisible reproductive work (Vértiz Márquez, 2024) and emotional labor (Yee et al., 2024) put into organizing our workshops—historically associated with women’s labor (see also Federici, 2018). We iteratively drew up themes and critically evaluated our experiments and research data in four reflective sessions. We met online many times, and we exchanged several emails, which included details of our personal lives, reproductive work, health conditions, travel plans, institutional burdens, and national/international political events that we wanted to share as part of our geographically distributed workplace.

POSITIONING COMMONS AND COMMONING

Our entry point into the intersection of commons and design lies in Participatory Design (PD). During the past decade, PD has increasingly moved beyond workplaces and engaged with public areas and wider issues of social and ecological justice (Smith et al., 2025). In this context, PD scholars have started to question the central role of consensus in participatory processes, unpacking other nuances of democratic participation (Björgvinsson et al., 2012a; Björgvinsson et al., 2012b). When PD and other co-design endeavours shifted their focus toward communal everyday life settings, PD scholars began to explore more autonomous and self-governing aspects of design and suggested learning from the scholarship on commons (Marttila et al., 2014; Seravalli, 2018).

This evolution towards ‘collectiveness’ in design has engendered the need for new vocabularies and perspectives (Huybrechts et al., 2025). For example, the notion of commoning has been used as an invitation to rethink the relationships and roles of actors or entities in commons arrangements (Marttila & Botero, 2017; Poderi, 2019; Poderi, 2021), and as a frame to discuss intertwined social practices (Teli et al., 2016; Teli et al., 2017; Cibin et al., 2020b), as well as a tool for strategizing and locating socio-material practices as a part of city-making and urban commons (Marttila & Botero, 2016; Parker & Schmidt, 2017; Seravalli, 2018; Botero & Saad-Sulonen, 2019), the strengthening of local democracy and exploration of the political dimensions (Hillgren et al., 2016), online collaboration and documentation practices of commons-oriented groups (Botero & Saad-Sulonen, 2019; Kohtala et al., 2019; Van Amstel et al., 2016), and the grassroots organization of welfare practices (Teli et al., 2018; Sciannamblo et al., 2021) or of media services (Cibin et al., 2019).

As this growing literature shows, commons and commoning in design research, especially in PD, is informing and transforming design practices and processes in multiple contexts, including humans and other-than-humans in the activity of design. Yet, there is much less discussion on the subjective implications of commoning and designing togethers. In a sense, our proposal is to reflect on our shared journey of becoming participatory design commoners while trying to understand how other design researchers have done a similar thing in their different contexts. We have thus documented a shared methodological reflection on how relational perspectives can support designers who engage with commons, and how commoning can inform ways social encounters and relations are structured. At the same time, we explored how designing can shape the relational production of collective resources and ownership arrangements.

RELATIONAL DIMENSIONS IN DESIGN

This research addresses a shift in how professional designers approach agency and collective action in design work. For an increasing number of design researchers, agency is a relational property of socio-material assemblages (Latour, 2005), not an essential feature of a person. For example, Pelle Ehn (2008) has explored a design practice concerned with “Things”, that can inquire “into the ‘agency’ of not only designers and users but also of non-human ’actants’ such as objects, artifacts, and design devices" (Ehn, 2008 p. 1; see also Binder et al., 2011). In a similar vein, Björgvinsson et al. (2012a) argue the need for infrastructuring relationships around Things, as open-ended arenas for experimenting and negotiating those same relationships. Agid (2016) suggests a framework to critically examine designers’ dynamic positions, relational practices, and roles in infrastructuring Things. They emphasize that both the design and interpretation of continuously evolving relational practices are important in fostering shared socio-political possibilities (Agid, 2016; see also Light et al., 2024).

Another notable shift involves scholars advocating for the inclusion of perspectives of other-than-human entities and their relations into design endeavours (e.g., Akama et al., 2020; Light, 2023; Haldrup et al., 2022; Heitlinger et al., 2025). In tandem, the pluriverse envisioned by Arturo Escobar (2018) through his relational ontology inspired design researchers to design for and across a “world of many worlds” (Leitão, 2023; Leitão et al., 2024). While working across worlds within worlds, design researchers are becoming more aware of the need to reflect on their positionalities, privileges, and biases (Agid, 2016; Agid & Akama, 2018; Akama

et al., 2019; Van Amstel et al., 2021; Mugnaini et al. 2025). This call for radical inclusivity and reflexivity aligns with the broader discourse of addressing the relational politics of design (Escobar et al., 2024; Akama, 2015; Heitlinger et al., 2025).

Against this backdrop, the 'collective resource approach' (the Scandinavian assemblage from which PD emerged from, (Ehn & Kyng, 1987; Ehn, 1993), the 'collective action' of managing a common-pool resource (Ostrom 1990), and 'co-design', understood as designing Things together, (Ehn 2008) do not seem enough for contemporary relational design practice. Instead, applying the lens of relational ontology brings back the somewhat forgotten notion of the "collective designer", as "someone who recognize the collective and political character of the design process and takes a humanistic stance in design issues" (Ehn & Badham, 2002, p. 2). This notion is relevant to contemporary design research on decolonizing design bodies (Angelon & Van Amstel, 2021) and post-humanist cyborgs (Forlano & Glabau, 2024). Seen as collective designers, these monstrous bodies invite us to explore complex affective relations in the making.

The collective designer can, thus, be related to the growing interest for relationality in PD. Yoko Akama and Ann Light (2018; 2020; Light & Akama, 2012; 2014) and their many collaborators (e.g., Agid & Akama, 2018; Akama et al., 2019, Akama et al., 2020, Light et al., 2024) have been developing theoretical foundations for relational approaches and sensibilities for relations in design. Akama and Light (2018; 2020) stress the importance of cultivating 'relational sensitivity' in PD practices and suggest two positions to engage in relational ontology: poise – an awareness of how oneself is and acts, and punctuation – an awareness of relational dynamics. In emphasizing the contextual and dynamic nature of relational qualities, Akama et al. (2019) highlight that these qualities are "highly contextualized, shaped, and constituted by our whole selves in relational work with others" (p. 17). Therefore, it becomes important for designers and design researchers to continuously position themselves within their relational contexts, carefully considering how they engage in the processes of designing and commoning.

The cultivation of a "situated and responsive awareness" is deemed essential to prevent falling into the pitfalls of adopting a detached or design from 'nowhere' perspective that seeks clear-cut relations (Akama et al., 2019). Relations often take form in the in-between place where actors are interconnected, like Agid (2016) describes: "being-in-relation-to each other and to the work, the artifacts and systems… (p. 87)". As for Cipolla and Manzini (2009) "relation is a result of 'openness' to others, … when one human being turns to another human being as a 'presence' the possibility of relation arises, moving from 'I-It' experiences to 'I-Thou' relations and vice versa." (p. 47). Akama (2015) emphasizes such in-betweenness because "co-designing is performed and emerges from relational sensitivity". A relational approach in co-design demands a heightened awareness of design's positioning within complex layers of "power, knowledge, practices, cultural values, and precarious asymmetries" as inherent conditions for collaboration (Akama et al., 2019, p. 1).

For designing and commoning, relationality brings into view how commons are arranged and maintained, what responsibilities and privileges they render, and the ways these different layers are negotiated to become a relational inquiry (Poderi et al., 2022). Resource use, access, rights, and 'ownership' are all relational, and need to be addressed collectively by design. As commons scholars Bollier and Helfrich (2019) write: "... to relationalize property means to arrange the enactment of use rights in ways that nourish our relationships to each other, the nonhuman world, and past and future generations". That means to "recognize and honor a wide range of relationships" and be accountable for these relations, to oneself, to others and more-than-human entities (p. 241). Light and Miskelly (2015) go as far as to recognize "relational assets" while studying cultures of sharing in local neighbourhoods. These assets are shared and place-based resources emerging over time, which are available by those having access to the place. As can be seen, relationality foregrounds how PD in commoning and designing unfolds over time, yet can be affected by external factors, experiences, feelings, and other evolving dynamics.

THREE EXPERIMENTS ON CONFIGURING RELATIONS IN COMMONING AND DESIGNING

To highlight relationality in commoning and designing, we draw on our experiences, encounters, and on the materials from three thematic workshops organized for and with design practitioners and scholars in the context of international design conferences. All three workshops shared the key objective to probe the relationship between design and commons—and designing and commoning—while exploring collaborations between human and other-than-human entities. Each workshop approached the theme differently, building upon the experiences and knowledge developed from earlier ones. The workshops also experimented and investigated the process of co-creating shared common-pool resources as "relational assets" (Light & Miskelly, 2015). We describe them here with some detail as part of the strategy of articulating and reflecting on our own attempts for supporting commoning, and our design of relational designs and practices.

THE FIRST WORKSHOP, *Commoning Design and Designing Commons*, was an interactive online workshop organized as part of the Participatory Design Conference (PDC) in June 2020. The session invited the community to reflect and discuss specific issues, such as: "how can participatory design remain open to multiple ways of sharing and different worldviews? What would it mean for the participatory design community in terms of challenging established notions such as participation, facilitation, empowerment, to name but a few?" (Botero et al., 2020). We had asynchronous preliminary online activities in groups (April—June 2020) and a half-day online synchronous session (16 June 2020) with both focused group discussions and plenary activities. Before the synchronous session, participants were broken into groups of four people. Through some asynchronous collaboration, each group curated a list of keywords inspired by each other's position statements submitted prior to the workshop (Fig. 1). In the workshop we started collaborative brainstorming and writing supported by online tools (Etherpad, Onlyoffice), and our loose adaptation of the Open Space Technology method using the video conference "Breakout rooms" (Zoom) to allow virtual room hopping.

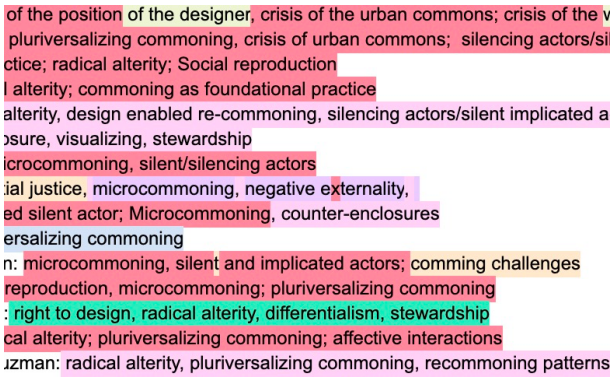


Figure 1: A list of keywords inspired by participants' position statements submitted prior to the workshop. Screen shot from Etherpad used for the online session.

Using the initial co-created set of keywords, we started to enrich and produce content on the various dimensions of commoning and design. We later called this collaborative effort *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck*, and decided to keep a collective authorship attribution as P.D. Commoners, rather than individuals when we had to define the slide-deck authorship in the publishing system. We wanted to keep up with the participatory design tradition of identifying the collective designer (Ehn & Badham, 2002) through pseudonyms like A.Telier (Binder et al., 2011).

In making a slide-deck together we aimed to create a resource that could represent the plurality of voices and experiences, interpretations, definitions, and meanings that can characterize commons. Keeping the multiple perspectives on designing with, while respecting, and acknowledging the ontological differences between the universes they dwell in was not easy. To aid our understanding, the first version of the slide-deck also included definitions of terms and practices that at that time populated commons discourse within the field of design research, as well as few concrete examples and case descriptions of commoning and PD initiatives in this area brought by participants. The co-created and publicly available slide-deck (Commoners, P.D, 2020) supports conversations between people interested in the relationship between commoning and designing and provides a shared vocabulary to discuss this relationship. We decided that the slide-deck should encourage contributions from other commoners as well as creation of new derivative works. Hence, the deck is licensed with a Creative Commons by-non-commercial-share-alike license (BY-NC-SA) that permits sharing, expanding, and building upon the original work.

THE SECOND WORKSHOP, with the same title as the first one, was organized in conjunction with the DRS conference in June 2022 in Bilbao, Spain (Marttila et al., 2022). The workshop continued the research agenda that was set in the previous one in exploring and contributing to the relationship between commoning and designing, now in a face-to-face setting. In practice, we invited the participants to share and reflect on these connections by sharing practical and/or theoretical experiences and examples from their own work as design practitioners or design scholars. We proposed possible questions for exploration: "What could be considered good strategies and practices for sustainable and enduring commoning and commons design? What can design researchers, activists, and practitioners contribute to the commons, and how? How does commoning/designing change when resources and assets are in common ownership?" (Marttila et al., 2022).

The full-day workshop was carried out in person around facilitated group discussions, co-creation activities and plenary sessions. After the thematic introduction by the workshop's initiators and organizers, the first group discussion session focused on understanding different understandings and takes on the notion of commons, and thereafter discussing what defines commons to the participants in their professional practice (Fig. 2). Inspiration for the prompts for the group discussion was taken from the *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck 2.0* resource co-created in the first workshop. We all thought about specific commons we engaged with and reflected on the social practices and dynamics related to the commons and human and other-than-human actors connected to it.

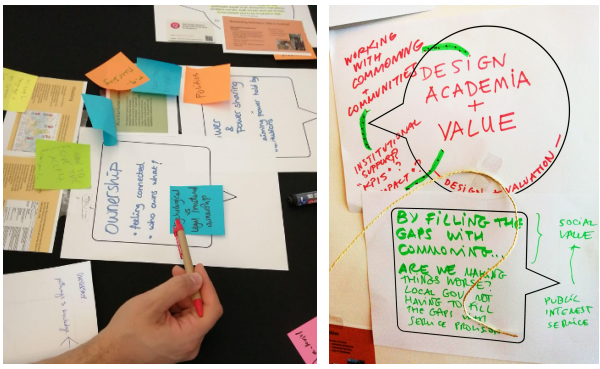


Figure 2: Workshop participants identifying and discussing themes related to designing and commoning. Photos: P.D. Commoners.

In the second session of the workshop, we had a closer look on discourse and dialogue around designing and commoning. As workshop organizers, we had prepared quotes found from selected literature and from recorded discussions with scholars and practitioners. The quotes were placed on the wall along printed slides from the slide-deck. We walked around in pairs or groups of three and got familiar with the different perspectives on commoning, adding our own as speech bubbles, bringing insights from the discussions in the groups or our individual perspectives. While doing this, we highlighted interesting themes and added comments and questions as written annotations to these perspectives (see Fig. 3). In the next round of reflections, we made linkage between speech bubbles, made thematic connections, and reorganized them on the wall. We collectively selected and prioritized relevant themes for a future research agenda on designing commons and commoning design. Thus, we attempted to perform together as a collective P.D. Commoners by creating seeds for a joint design research agenda for designing commoning and commoning design.

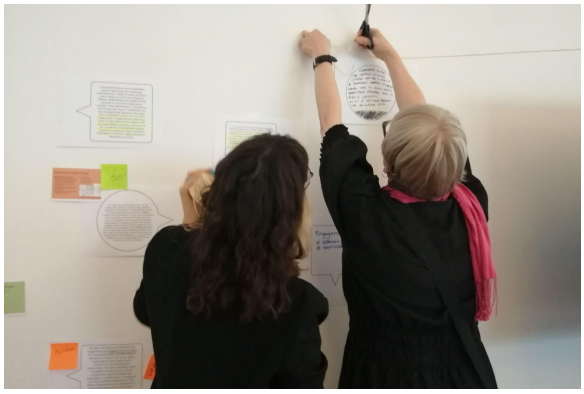


Figure 3: Workshop participants making thematic connections on the wall. Photo: P.D. Commoners.

The workshop ended with a plenary discussion where we shared selected key insights and reflections and reflected on the process of the workshop experiment and our collective effort.

THE THIRD WORKSHOP titled *Relationality, Commoning and Designing*, was held online, as two separate sessions at the PDC conference in 2022 (Poderi et al., 2022). In the sessions, we invited the PD community to engage with questions such as: "how do we embrace and rely upon relationality when designing collectively and in a participatory manner within other-than-human ensembles? How do we become commoners and what do we nurture in common? What do we lose and what do we gain by considering commons with a keen eye on relationality? Which kind of relational qualities are essential for commoning design and designing commons?" (Poderi et al., 2022, p. 255). One week before the workshop, we invited newcomers to join a group chat on Signal to engage with some lightweight activities and interactions before and in between the two sessions. As organizers, we introduced ourselves, the scope of the workshop, its activities, and prompted the participant for contributions using video and texts. In an explicit attempt to care for forming relations, we encouraged people to bring small, shared meals (breakfast, lunch, dinner depending on participant's time zone) as part of the workshop, instead of having a more traditional coffee break.

During the workshop, we used a mix of digital tools to support building relations and collaboration, (e.g., browser-based tool Miro, Zoom, and Signal). In the first online session, we all shared a picture of ourselves on a shared board (Miro), which we had previously seeded with images of concepts and places with annotations. Afterward, in the second session, we invited everyone to draw connections and relations to each other's online collages. This activity was followed by sharing some inspirations and conceptualizations found in the literature on relationality (see Fig. 4 below).

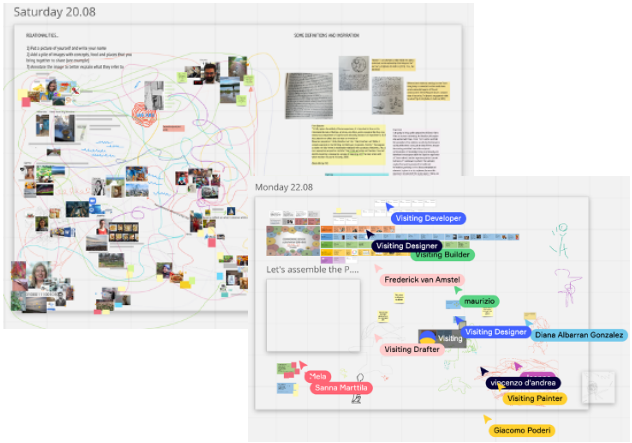


Figure 4: Screen captures of the collective work on the Miro board.

In the next activity, we explored relationality as related to the body, even though we were not physically present together. We drew our own bodies with our eyes closed on the Miro board while listening to selected Brazilian songs about collective bodies. This is a remote adaptation of the classic "draw your own body" dramatic game from Theater of the Oppressed (Boal, 2022). After drawing ourselves individually, we assembled the “monstrous collective design body” (Angelon & Van Amstel, 2021). We purposefully let its body look like a visual mess because we did not want to homogenize the body differences among us (see Fig. 6 below).

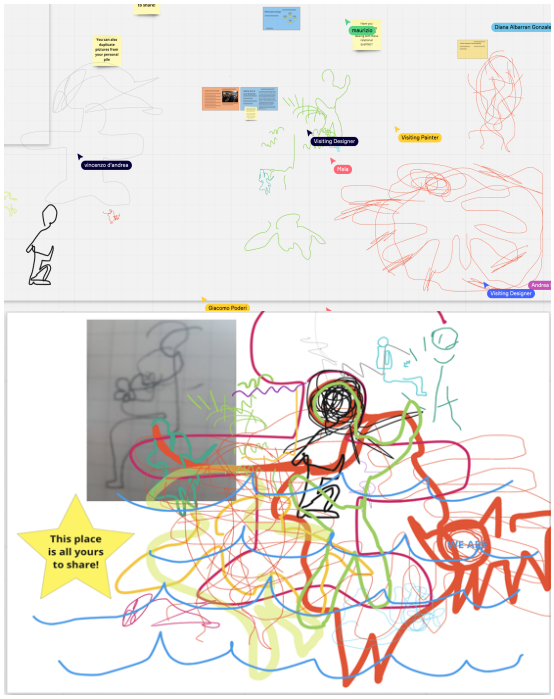


Figure 6: Playing the "Draw your own body" dramatic game on an online whiteboard. The assembled drawings of P.D. Commoner collective design body.

REFLECTIONS ON THE BECOMINGS OF A PARTICIPATORY DESIGN COMMONER

We have briefly outlined some of the structures and ideas proposed to explicitly support relational and commoning aspects within the design process itself. We now shift our focus to tracing this issue at a more intimate scale through two interrelated themes: First, the ways of being in commons as a professional designer and a design researcher. Second, affective relations and their qualities contributing to and sustaining the commons. When tracing these relations, the notions of “relational qualities” (Cipolla & Manzini, 2009) and “relational assets” (Light & Miskelly, 2015) are helpful to explore how relations contribute to the overall fabric of commons, and agency in commoning and designing.

RETHINKING THE ROLE OF THE DESIGNER

In the workshops, designers and design researchers reported their troubled position in wanting to care for and contribute to the commons. They frequently spoke of their role of being a kind of translator between worlds. In the words of a participant: “a designer becomes a translator … translates existing practices into design language and legitimizes these practices…”; designers work for “cultural change for those who have not [yet] been exposed to commoning principles”. Alternatively, they also mentioned playing the role of a mediator, or someone who is “connecting with different institutions and works with different disciplines…” as well as helping “the commoners to identify the power that they hold, and how they can release that power to be more open”. (Quotes from the workshop participants, 2nd workshop).

The translator and mediator roles seem to coexist, and many participants felt comfortable shifting between them. However, having to perform roles also generated contradictions and dissonance. On one hand, other commoners sometimes expect professional designers to design for the commons, if not the commons itself. On the other hand, designers sometimes see themselves as commoners and refrain from taking an expert role: “I am doing the work as a commoner, but not as a professional designer and academic” (Participant, 2nd workshop). This contradiction between professional and everyday life positions has implications for designing while commoning: “... sometimes we just don’t need to design, maybe we can take a step back, ... and let other expert people to come up with something. …. sometimes I just have to say, I’d rather not design today, it is Sunday and design is my work so if I do my work in my free time as well…” (Participant, 2nd workshop). Reflecting on this contradiction, the participants pondered that, sometimes, “designers should just sit silent, maybe sit back and be part of the process, perhaps there is nothing to design” (Participants, 2nd workshop), alluding to a recognition that not all processes need to be (or could be) led, orchestrated, or even facilitated by designers acting in their professional capacities, and thus taking specific roles.

This move of stepping back, and having mutual influence in design space has been discussed in design research also before (e.g. in PD; Simonsen & Robertson, 2012). Articulating shared values instead of roles, has previously led to proposals such as the idea of a “sociable designer,” which emphasizes being social rather than merely designing social interactions (Tjahja & Yee, 2022). Shifting away from clearly defined roles, frames, and boundaries within commons may include more tensions and contradictions in the design space (see also Van Amstel et al., 2016). As one participant noted, while inclusion is essential for fostering diverse perspectives and constructive exchanges, it might

introduce frictions and messiness: "The more inclusionary places you have, the more homogeneity you have. In my experience in commons – I have been in both, very exclusive and very inclusive commons, the one of inclusive was very messy, and very difficult to work with." (Participant, 2nd workshop).

For many participants, it is clear that a reorientation towards commons and commoning design seems to require flexibility and willingness to share mandate, authority, power, and decision-making, and develop mechanisms of autonomy and self-governance, to and with fellow commoners. This is not to say that professional designers and their expertise are no longer needed. Rather it is to convey that, in the context of commons, designers can contribute to the commons and life-in-the-commons, as any other commoners, from their unique position, and personal and professional skill sets, factors, and qualities. If the object and focus of design is contributing to commons culture, then, a challenge for a professional designer, and for others navigating in and contributing to commons, is to deal with a new set of challenges and relational qualities such as fairness, trust, and intrinsic and social motivations as identified by the workshop participants in the 2nd workshop. For example, a workshop participant added the quality "Reciprocity" to the *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck 2.0* because "For a commons, it is essential to stimulate and accommodate the reciprocal actions among the participants even if that does not lead to an explicit contribution to the commons".

The relational assets for designing and commoning are located in-between humans and other-than-humans. Participants in the 2nd workshop suggested that commoning practices should include: identifying and making visible relations, and especially, multiple nuances of labor put in commons, such as "small, tedious tasks that are not often recognized" as one of the participants described. These mundane and small contributions are not often recognized as work (Yee et al., 2024; Vértiz Marquez, 2024; Botero et al., 2020; Akama & Light, 2018), and can impact commoners' motivation and level of commitment; "…some people are staying with the trouble and some are just bypassing and making small contributions." (Participant, 2nd workshop). The everyday tasks undertaken by commoners while tending to the commons seem to be often overlooked and undervalued. By centering on emotions, it becomes evident that the act of caring for the commons is far from being taken lightly. It involves an ongoing ethical and political effort that requires constant acknowledgment and is interconnected with emotional states, both influencing and being influenced by them (Poderi, 2021; Fritch et al., 2022).

Weaving together contexts, social practices and other results is an important part of the work done to produce conditions that can nurture and sustain commons and commoning for different temporalities (i.e. building on the efforts of the past, producing for the future). The concept of "Stewardship" was considered as an interesting way to articulate such an activity, as it "assumes everyone's right to participate, with distributed expertise, in access and sharing". (Participant, 1st workshop) When design activities are oriented towards feeding a commons culture, articulation work is pivotal. Continuous reflexivity and articulation of invisible and affective labour is important for commons as they are constantly becoming, and un-becoming settled in social and natural relations. In other words, the relational qualities that sustain the commons change through time and therefore require articulation to shape and preserve the stories of the past, and at the same time enhance future uses and aid onboarding of possible newcomers (Botero & Saad-Sulonen, 2019). When co-producing *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck* (Workshop 1), the notion of "discursive actors" was brought forward: these actors "are made present through the discourse of others who are already participating" and forming a collective identity. Articulating relational qualities is fundamental, as commoners do not become so in a vacuum, they become together.

Previous scholar and practitioner accounts have made it visible how design projects, programs, and their funding instruments intrinsically guide and frame design efforts and roles and responsibilities, including the design and decision-making mandate (e.g. Lyle et al., 2018). Prendeville and Kohtala (2023) have also problematized academics' attempts to engage or commence commons initiatives, as they can bring along their organizational frames to commons. A similar concern was highlighted by some participants who noted that design researchers can bring objectives and metrics to the commons through their institutional logics and mechanisms: "as an academic I belong to an institution, ... and we need to talk about the role of our institutions. How our, possibly quite neo-liberal, universities support or don't support commoning. Is it part of the agenda? How does it fit into design research? Is it about doing commoning, and then writing a paper about it?" (Participant, 2nd workshop).

If not properly taken care of, institutionalized practices such as requiring consensus to move a collective forward can sideline and undermine commoning practices, and at worst, destroy commons altogether. This is not to convey that commons should intentionally seek dissensus. Bjögvinsson et al., (2012b), have rightly pointed out that consensus should not necessarily be a desired outcome of participation, and that dissonance and disagreements between different actors is part of living in common. From this vantage point, becoming a participatory design commoner is then a strategic move from seeing design as giving form and structure, or

solving and taming complicated entanglements of relations, to embracing people's varying or competing visions, motivations, and levels of contributions. This change of perspective can also mean a step away from serving and contributing to common good and common objective, ideals that are often connected to commoning and designing. For scholars and practitioners, life-in-the-commons as commoners could also mean rejecting and rethinking design research funding, and questioning who is benefiting from such funding, and what distribution of such funding would strengthen the commons and its relationships.

AFFECTIVE RELATIONS

Organizing these experimental workshops and our discussions in them has also brought forward the importance of considering affective relations and their qualities in commons. This means making room for emotions and tensions that emerge in these entanglements, the so-called "matters of care" (de La Bellacasa, 2017; Eleutério & Van Amstel, 2020). When the participants of the 3rd workshop were invited to edit and enhance *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck* (V2.0) with the perspective of relational qualities, (described as "aesthetic/ethical perceptions that emerge from the relations that people foster around or within a commons"), they foregrounded qualities such as "intimacy" and "vulnerability", and the need for having "honesty", "solidarity", "reciprocity" and "trust" when engaging with commons. These relational qualities in designing and commoning can be associated with caring for the self and for the others, including other than human entities, in every day, and when facing trouble (Sciannamblo et al., 2021; Light, 2023). Unsurprisingly these identified qualities echo earlier work within design research. For example, Karasti, (2014) and later Pihkala and Karasti (2022) discuss committed 'care work' in Community PD as responsible, sustainable technology design with a long-term perspective. Similarly, Light and Akama (2014) examine the political dimensions of participation by focusing on the mutual reliance of individuals, employing feminist notions of 'care' to investigate the ethical responsibilities inherent in the design process. Moreover, Light and Seravalli's (2019) analysis of care in co-creation initiatives between citizens and municipalities highlights "relations of reciprocal accountability and mutual commitment", an active and continuous effort to care (Light & Seravalli, 2019).

At the convergence of the existing literature and our democratic design experiments, we find that becoming a participatory design commoner requires decentering individual (and professional) perspectives to a commons and collective view, and from a human to an other-than-human ontology towards designing and commoning with emotions and feelings included. Nevertheless, sometimes it is challenging to set aside professionalism and other masks we might carry. In the third workshop, we as facilitators and participants, paid attention to the importance of small cracks in these façades as ways of relating and to build affective relations such as belonging, empathy and trust. In the workshop, these ways of relating included showing the physical space where working from (e.g., some participated from their kitchen instead of their office due to lingering effects of COVID-19 pandemic measures), bringing everyday practices or a hobby to the professional context (e.g., knitting during a workshop session), or doing a mundane task or sharing an everyday moment (like cooking or eating together). These ways of relating to others can be seen as ways of being 'one's authentic self' while engaging with other 'selves'. The process of becoming one out of many is a slow, affective, and often surprising process.

Commons, and their related arrangements and practices of commoning speak to forms of collective action that rely on intrinsic motivation mechanisms, including voluntary work, new forms of membership and collective ownership, all of which potentially reframe what counts as designing and who participates (see e.g. Light & Akama, 2012). For design research, this means critically revisiting and perhaps deconstructing some of the key notions linked to designing commons. Some of the participants in the 2nd workshop dissected their understanding of 'ownership' by questioning "who owns and what". It makes a difference, whether the point of departure of discussing ownership is legal or psychological. In the latter, the ownership is seen through qualities such as accountability, sense of belonging, self-efficacy and self-identity (Peck et al., 2021), while legal ownership revolves around categories such as property, rights, access and use.

When probing relational qualities, some participants suggested qualities such as the Spanish word "Complementaridad", referring to a work of Solón et al. (2017), who describe it as: "... to complement is to combine forces and optimize the potentialities of each one of us towards embracing the whole in its multiple dimensions", and "Reciprocity" as a way of relating and bonding by "giving and receiving, going beyond transactions… reciprocity is a mutual agreement from a place of support and care, not for power or monetary interest." (Participants, workshop 3). In a similar fashion, "Parietarity" was put forward as a capability to create and maintain commons in a legally hostile environment (e.g. in a legal framework where IPR regulates collective life leaving no space to bottom-up and spontaneous initiative, inspired by a plant called "Parietaria officinalis", which " is a plant that grows in walls and cracks in the streets" (Participants, workshop 3). The suggested relational qualities and vocabulary propose alternatives on how we discuss 'ownership' and what use, access, rights, and ownership could mean. This resonates with Bollier and Helfrich's (2019)

thinking on how to "decommodify access and use rights" through 'relationalizing', in which people are by design expected voluntarily to be accountable for their relationships and for the commons. Here, the object of the design is the socio-material assemblage of tools, mechanisms and arrangements, all permeated by care relations. Thus, how the commons are arranged, what responsibilities and privileges it establishes, and how 'ownership' and various relationships are negotiated becomes a matter of configuring relations, "a relational inquiry in commons" (Bollier & Helfrich, 2019). Hence, 'relational assets' (Light & Miskelly, 2015) and the 'design of relational practices' (Agid, 2016) becomes relevant to commoning as much as to designing.

TOWARDS A COLLECTIVE DESIGNER

In the three workshops we were, on one hand, exploring and establishing relationships and relational assets, and on the other hand, experimenting with forming a collective design body, a participatory design commoner. What then constitutes this relational designer? How can we sensitize a collective design body to emerge? In the workshops we experimented with multiple tactics, including co-creating relational assets and common-pool resources. For example, the 1st workshop, the participants engaged in the production of *Commoning Design: A Pluriversal Slide-Deck*, and thus formed a collective designer whose efforts were attributed to the alias P.D. Commoners instead of individually named contributors. Similarly, the 2nd workshop explored the building of a temporary knowledge base weaving together previous written accounts on commoning and designing, and participants' own practical and theoretical experiences and examples when engaging in and with commons. The aim was to lay the seeds for a research agenda or a manifesto to understand relational commons, and the relationship between "commoning practices" and "design practices". The workshop's agenda took the form of a wall poster where different perspectives were co-reported, enriched and annotated by the participants. Again, the knowledge production was carried out as a collective. In the 3rd workshop, we adopted a more affective and relational approach to collective knowledge production informed by feminist and indigenous approaches. The online participants behaved similar to a flock of birds, gathering around an issue or a creative task, and then breaking apart to dive deep into interpersonal feelings, emotions, and experiences. This interplay with some affective enablers (e.g., music, the soundscape of the bonfire, sharing personal space) or sensitizers (by focusing on other senses, e.g. closing eyes when drawing) resulted in reflections primarily on relational qualities and affective relations. Here, a participatory design commoner was performed and experimented through drawing a collective design body and then summoned together with an imaginary bonfire on Zoom.

This relational approach to commons, and commoning and designing means a turn to the pluriverse (Escobar 2018). As Akama et al. (2019) relay, "relational co-designing means abandoning the singularity, universality, and replicability of a "best practice model" (p. 19). With our experiences, we aimed to configure and try out what it means to move away from individual-centered design paradigms towards a collective-distributed design body that emerges amid differences.

To encapsulate our reflections on these experiments and to further the dialectics of commoning and designing, we share three design principles to becoming a participatory design commoner. First, **1) building capacity for critical self-consciousness and self-reflexivity** as crucial to understanding oneself, recognizing and articulating one's background, privileges, and biases, and positioning oneself in relation to others. Akama and Light (2020) refer to this as the "readiness" of a designer, a capability to draw from one's own experiences and dynamic "relational practices" (Agid, 2016) to design and be designed as a human and other-than-human collective body. From this, we concur that **2) engaging with others is as important as engaging with the self**, both from a human and an other-than-human perspective. That means including technology mediated interactions and their mediating artifacts – online boards, videos, collages – as part of the collective design body. This relational work is necessary for sustaining the fundamental characteristics of the commons (openness, participation, coexistence, etc.) in the long run. Thus, we finally pose that **3) whatever is created out of this process of mutual becoming is shared in the same spirit**. At this stage, designers may take on the role of suggesting tools, tactics, and mechanisms for mediating and managing cultural rites, ownership, access, and use rights within the commons. This also includes shaping and preserving past voices and narratives while simultaneously enhancing future use. These steps in designing and commoning can lead newcomers to develop a sensibility for relational qualities that emerge in commons such as vulnerability, solidarity, trust and complementarity, as articulated by the participants in the workshops. While following the principles stated above, newcomers learn what it takes to become a collective designer and commoner at the same time.

From this shared lived experience and research effort, we speculate on a possible reorientation for PD, and its implications to professional practice. PD endeavours have been a political strategy and vehicle for increasing the democratic qualities of design and society since the 1970s (Ehn, 2008; Simonsen & Robertson, 2012). PD achieves this by doing design research on how to

facilitate and mediate participation, expand design space, and build empowering artifacts. PD tactics, practices, and principles put emphasis on qualities and ideals such as mutual learning and alignment, shared language, and objectives, and this emphasis is here to stay while changing shape and transforming alongside technological opportunities and social transformations. The design principles we just introduced are a contribution towards this needed expansion.

CONCLUSIONS

We addressed the conference's call to explore relational design by reflecting on the awakening of a new (somewhat monstrous) collective designer, P.D. Commoners, while organizing workshops on commoning and designing. We discussed the changing role and position of designers, emphasizing their participation in creating and contributing to commons, with a specific focus on the relational qualities and affective relations that emerge at the intersection of designing and commoning. The thematic workshops served as an avenue to critically explore and reflect together on ways of relating and creating relations in commons with design practitioners and scholars, providing a fruitful approach to begin sharing our understandings of the relations between commons and design and designing and commoning.

What might a new paradigm of relational design look like when designing and commoning coincide, and perhaps merge? As suggested by the workshop participants, new capacities and capabilities are needed to place emphasis on relational qualities in design, such as fairness, trust, and intrinsic and social motivations when engaging with commons and other commoners. There is also a need to continue learning how to share mandate, authority, power, and decision-making, and develop mechanisms of autonomy and self-governance. Drawing insights from the relational qualities identified and reflected upon in the workshops, some novel practices could include making visible the nuances of labour invested in commons and acknowledging different temporalities that come into play when engaging with commons. It involves rethinking how to support reciprocal actions and deconstructing the dominant understanding of ownership to encompass aspects of accountability, belonging, and identity. Additionally, reflexivity on our positionalities and recognizing the institutional logics and mechanisms we might bring to the commons and design are essential. Thus, the arrangement of commons, its associated responsibilities and privileges, and the affective relations that emerge from a collective design body become focal points of a relational design inquiry in commons.

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